Chapter 4 · Story

“I chose it” quietly becomes “it must be right.”

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

What makes honest revision easier?

A Review failures and compare options afresh.

B Remind Maya that a competent coordinator would know better.

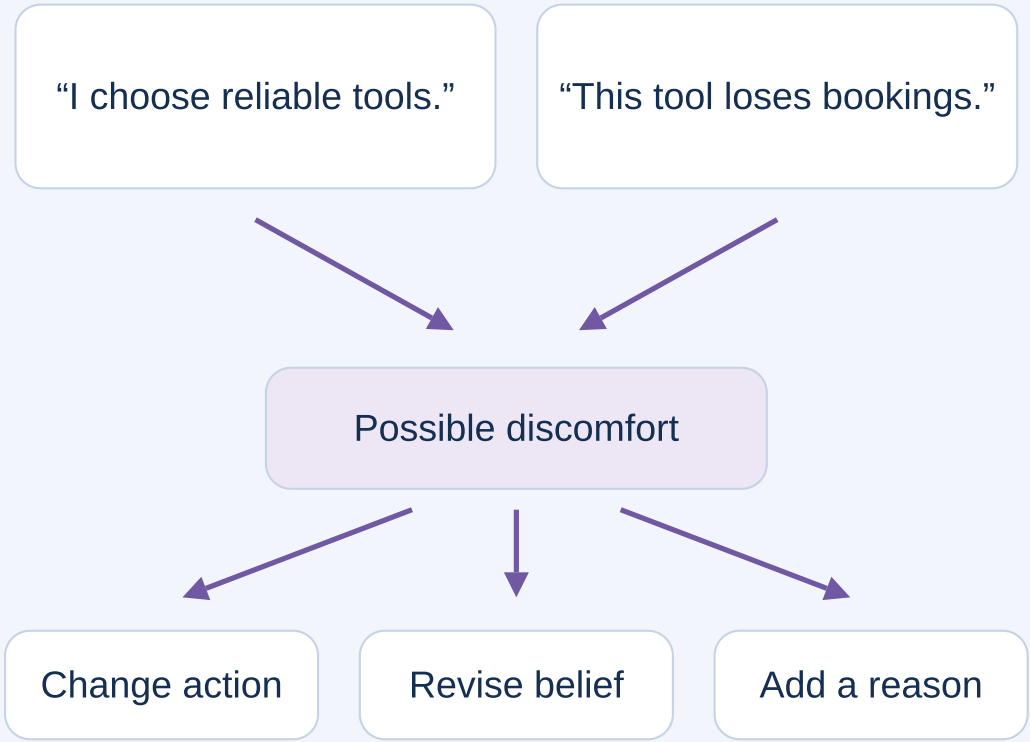
C Keep the system until the investment feels worthwhile.

Suggested answer: A. Reviewing failures and comparing options turns attention toward outcomes and the next decision.

Inconsistency can feel uncomfortable.

- **Cognitive dissonance**: inconsistency between beliefs or actions can feel uncomfortable.
- **Cognitions**: beliefs and knowledge about our actions.
- “I choose reliable tools” clashes with a system that loses bookings.
- Reduce discomfort by revising a belief or action, or adding a justification.

When beliefs and actions clash

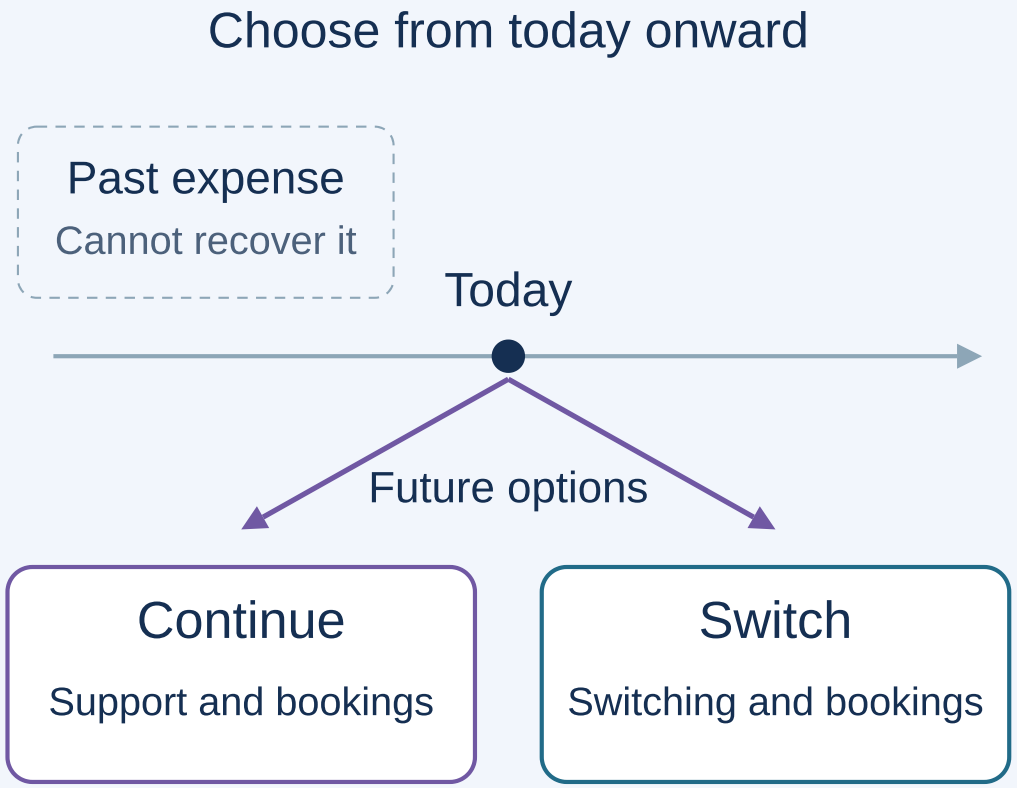


Cognitions are beliefs and knowledge about actions.

Inconsistency can motivate several different responses.

Give the future a fresh vote.

- **Sunk cost**: money, time, or effort that cannot be recovered.
- **Sunk cost effect**: letting that past expense drive the next choice.
- Compare future benefits and costs, including switching and usable skills.

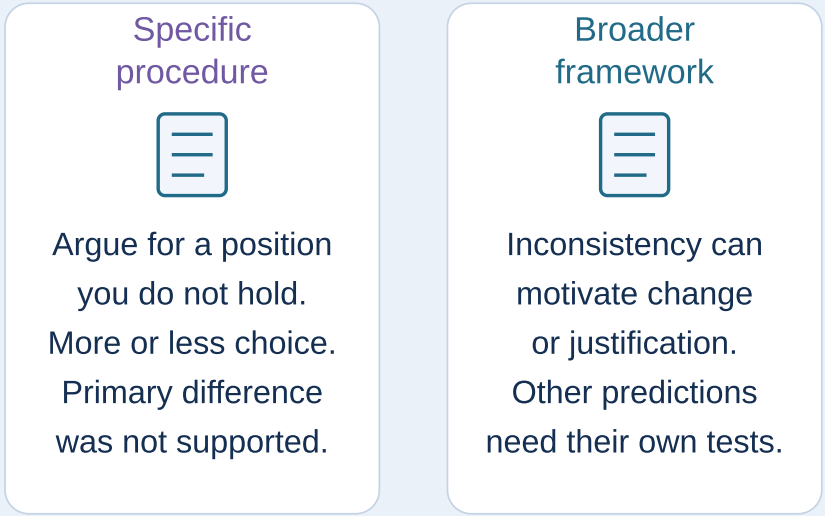


Past spending is unrecoverable; compare future consequences.

What can we really conclude?

Evidence for specific cognitive dissonance demonstrations is uneven. In 2024, researchers repeated one procedure across multiple laboratories. Participants were asked to argue for a position they did not hold, with more or less choice about doing so. This is called an induced-compliance procedure. The study tested whether the amount of choice affected later attitudes. Its primary analysis did not support the predicted difference between the higher-choice and lower-choice groups. That result challenges the particular procedure tested. It does not settle every version of cognitive dissonance theory. Distinguish the broad explanation of discomfort and justification from the evidence for a particular prediction. The linked Vaidis and colleagues study provides the details.

A tested prediction and a broader theory



The 2024 replication tests a particular procedure. Its result does not settle every dissonance claim.

The cited replication concerns a particular induced-compliance procedure.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Switching costs £100; keeping the tool costs £300 in future support. Benefits are equal. What matters?

A The large fee already paid.

B The lower avoidable future cost of switching.

C Only the emotional discomfort of switching.

Suggested answer: B. Under the stated assumptions, switching costs one hundred pounds and keeping the tool costs three hundred. Real choices also compare risks.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> Name two ways to reduce dissonance.

> When can a past investment still matter?

1. People may reduce dissonance by changing a behavior or belief, or by adding a justification. Context affects the response.

2. A past investment matters when it changes future consequences, such as switching costs or usable skills.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Revisit a small commitment you can change. List the future benefits and avoidable costs of continuing or stopping. Write a sentence that permits correction without attacking your character.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.